

Loneliness through the lens Sensory Processing Sensitivity

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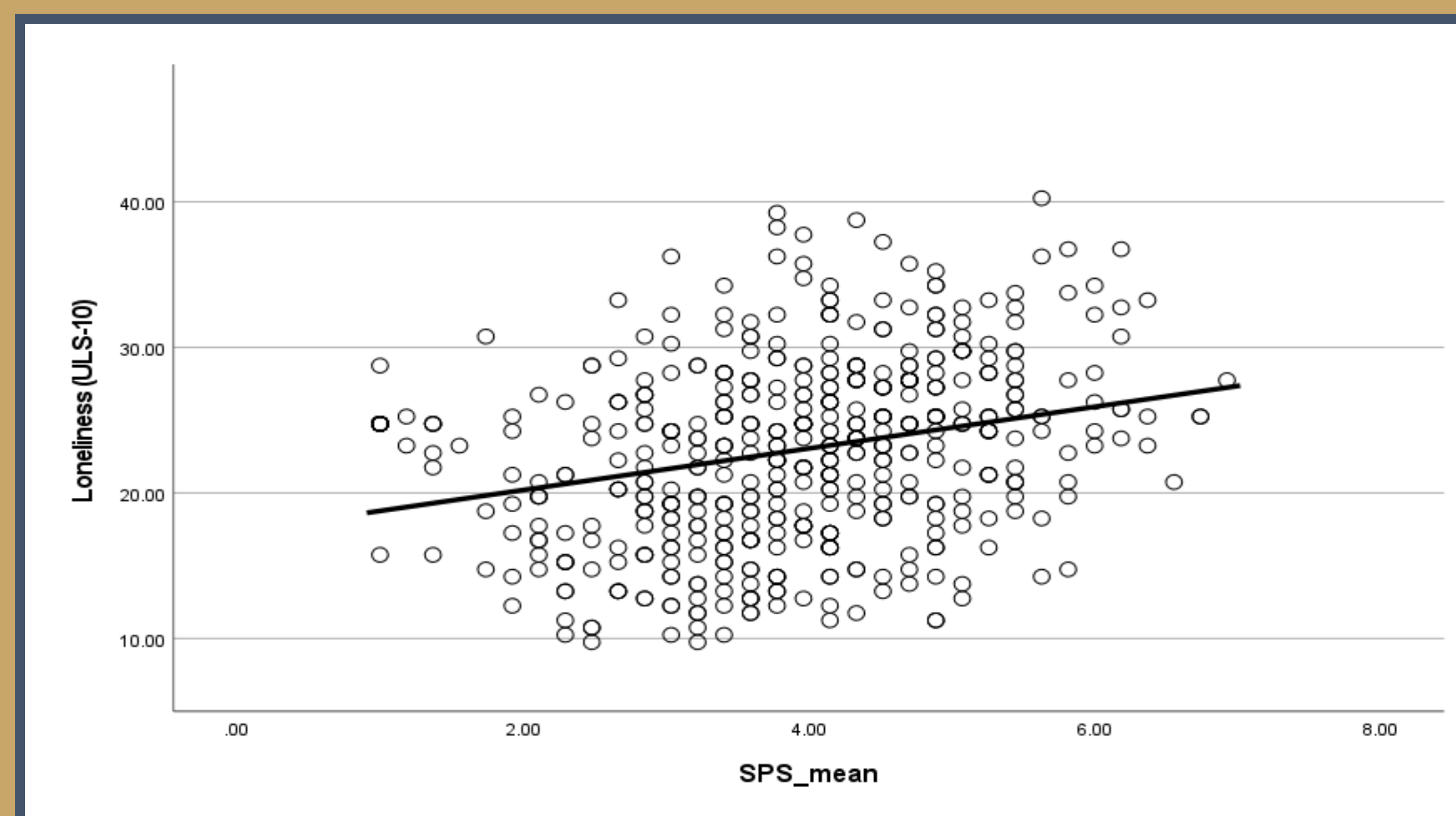
Methods

A total of 517 undergraduate students (69.8% female; 92.8% Hispanic; mean age = 20.26, SD = 4.16) completed an online survey that included the 27-item Highly Sensitive Person Scale (HSPS; Aron & Aron, 1997) and the 10-item UCLA Loneliness Scale (ULS-10; Russell, 1996). The HSPS provides a global score of sensory processing sensitivity but can also be examined as three factors: ease of excitation (EOE), low sensory threshold (LST) and aesthetic sensitivity (AES).

Results

Bivariate correlation analysis, using the Pearson correlation coefficient with 5,000 bootstrapped samples, revealed a statistically significant positive correlation between mean SPS score and loneliness, $r(517) = .275, p < .001$.

Additionally, our analysis revealed that two of the three subfactors (EOE and LST) were significantly positively correlated with loneliness ($r(517) = .253, p < .001$ and $r(517) = .315, p < .001$, respectively), while AES showed no significant correlation with loneliness ($r(517) = .048, p = .139$).



Introduction

Loneliness is a pervasive issue, affecting up to one third of individuals in industrialized countries (Cacioppo and Cacioppo, 2018). Loneliness is linked to a range of adverse psychological and physical outcomes, including depression, anxiety, diminished quality of life, and reduced life satisfaction (Hawkley, 2022; Park et al., 2020; Holt-Lunstad et al., 2015). Underlying these facets of loneliness are individual differences in experience influenced by personality traits (Abdellaoui et al., 2018; Schermer & Martin, 2019). The current study examines trait Sensory Processing Sensitivity (SPS) as a predictor of loneliness, a trait that encompasses a heightened depth of processing, increased sensitivity to internal and external stimuli, and appreciation of environmental subtleties (Aron & Aron, 1997). We hypothesize that people with high SPS, marked by their heightened sensitivity to sensory input and a susceptibility to overstimulation, may experience greater loneliness. Additionally, we explore subfactors of SPS to determine which may be the most influential predictors.

Discussion

Our findings suggest that high SPS individuals may experience greater loneliness. Examination of the significant relationships between SPS subfactors (EOE and LST) and loneliness suggests that those scoring highly in those areas may engage in behaviors or experiences that foster feelings of loneliness. In contrast, AES subfactor showed no significant association with loneliness, highlighting the variability in how different aspects of SPS relate to loneliness.

While our study is limited to cross-sectional data, these results support the overall relationship between SPS and loneliness. Understanding how specific subfactors of SPS contribute to loneliness can inform future research and may lead to tailored interventions and support systems for individuals experiencing loneliness.

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